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Note by the President of the General Assembly

I have the honour to circulate, pursuant to decision 75/573 of 14 July 2021, the present compilation document of the statements delivered by Heads of State or other dignitaries by means of pre-recorded statements during the general debate and submitted to the President no later than the day on which the pre-recorded statement is played in the Assembly Hall.

The statements contained in the present document were delivered on the morning of Monday, 27 September 2021, at the 16th meeting of the General Assembly (see A/76/PV.16). Document A/76/332 and its addenda 1 through 12 contain the statements delivered at the 3rd, 4th, 6th, 7th and 9th through 17th meetings of the General Assembly (A/76/PV.3, A/76/PV.4, A/76/PV.6, A/76/PV.7 and A/76/PV.9-A/76/PV.17).

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Iceland (see also A/76/PV.16, annex I)

Address by Mr. Gudlaugur Thór Thórdarson, Minister for Foreign Affairs and International Development Cooperation of the Republic of Iceland

Delivered on Monday, 27 September 2021, at the 16th meeting of the General Assembly

Mr. President, excellencies, ladies, and gentlemen,

As we gather to discuss the state of global affairs, today's challenges may seem overwhelming and almost impossible to overcome.

However, as an optimist and a strong believer in multilateral cooperation, I have for the past five years stressed in my message to the General Assembly the importance of seeing the world of opportunity, the potential of our cooperation. My message today is no different: we cannot let global challenges divide us. On the contrary, we must for all sake unite.

We have our work cut out for us. Around the world, calls for human rights, peace, and stability are too often ignored. And the threat of climate change is no longer a distant phenomenon: it is here, and it is intensifying.

But only together, can we respond and recover. To build a more just and peaceful planet for all of us, we need all nations united, our United Nations.

Mr. President,

While in most developed countries we are turning a corner in our fight against the COVID-19, same cannot be said about all of the world. It is critical that we work together to ensure that vaccines reach all countries and peoples — rich and poor — and as soon as possible. Not only is this a fundamental matter of global solidarity, but also in the interest of us all.

Iceland is firmly committed to play its part. We have already contributed 1 billion Icelandic krona to the COVAX initiative and have started vaccine sharing through the same mechanism.

If anything, the pandemic has taught us that we are stronger together than apart.

It has also exposed the dangers of isolationism, disinformation, and distrust.

These lessons should not go to waste. It is critical that we demonstrate the strength and the honesty needed to learn, both from our successes and our failures, to better prevent, prepare, and respond to future crisis of this magnitude.

Mr. President,

While the consequences of the pandemic have been disastrous for our world, the effects of climate change are bound to be even worse.

The science and the signs are clear and sobering, and the plans are already in place. We need to respond now and honour our commitments from Paris as we set our eyes on Glasgow.

For our part, Iceland's ambition is to go beyond the Paris commitments.

This includes a reduction in greenhouse gas emissions by more than half by 2030, complete carbon neutrality by 2040 and becoming fossil-fuel free by 2050.

All of Iceland's electricity and close to 85 per cent of Iceland's total energy consumption comes from renewables. We aim to close the gap with electrification of transport and green hydrogen and e-fuels for heavy transport and machinery, fishing, shipping and aviation. Our long-term energy policy also focuses on substantially increasing energy efficiency and multiple use of energy resources.

Capturing and binding carbon is also an important pillar of our efforts, where we use both tried and tested nature-based solutions and innovative technologies.

Iceland is home to the world's largest plant that extracts carbon dioxide directly from the air and turns it into rock through the so-called Carbfix method. This technology has been developed out of the geothermal energy industry and will be applicable in many corners of the world to capture and store CO2 as solid-state rock.

Focusing on our own homework, however, is not enough. High-income countries must support lower income ones to advance their climate ambitions too. I am pleased to share that Iceland's contribution to international climate finance has more than doubled from 2018.

But Iceland's main contribution in the fight against climate change will continue to be our knowledge and experience in the use of green energy solutions. This is a global crisis, and we must rely on each other's expertise and knowledge.

Iceland is ready to play its part. As a Global Champion for Just and Inclusive Energy Transition, Iceland actively promotes the goal of achieving sustainable energy for all. Iceland has for decades contributed to this global agenda, through research, training, sharing of experience, and cooperation. As a Global Champion, we are now scaling up our efforts even further.

Mr. President,

The health of the World Oceans — our Blue Planet — is increasingly under pressure. Climate change, mismanagement, and pollution are leading to food insecurities, an alarming fall in biodiversity, and depletion of natural resources.

We must take concrete steps to make regional and international cooperation on Ocean Affairs stronger. And we must base our actions on the best scientific advice and the Law of the Sea — the very constitution of the Ocean.

Much can be learned from successful regional cooperation. The Arctic Council is a great example, which brings together governments, indigenous peoples, science, and various stakeholders to share knowledge and shape policy and action.

During Iceland's recent chairmanship of the Council, a special emphasis was placed on protecting marine and coastal ecosystems, resulting in a regional action plan to address marine litter in the Arctic. A small but important step in the right direction. Iceland is also among the group of countries pushing for a global agreement to fight marine plastic pollution.

Nature is firmly on our agenda in the coming months, including at the COP meetings on climate change, biodiversity, and desertification, as well as the UN Ocean Conference. Ecosystem restoration, both on land and in the oceans, is yet

another pressing global issue that must be tackled in unison by the international community. We need to connect the dots and focus on stronger commitments and more robust implementation.

This is the Decade of Action. The time to act is now.

Mr. President,

In recovering from the pandemic, we cannot revert to business as usual. We need to do better, and build a greener, bluer, and more equitable and sustainable future. The groundwork has already been laid with the 2030 Agenda. The Sustainable Development Goals are our global compass, and the Decade of Action reminds us of the urgency at hand.

Iceland is committed to promote SDG implementation at home and abroad. The Global Goals guide our growing official development assistance, under the overarching objective of poverty reduction and a strong focus on human rights, including gender equality, rights of children and LGBTI.

Recognising the essential role of broad ownership and involvement for development success, Iceland is also supporting private sector partners and civil society in their development and humanitarian work, making full use of their strength and know-how. Without the participation and inclusion of the private sector we will not achieve our goals.

Iceland's own experience speaks volumes about the value of inclusiveness and equality for sustainable development, particularly the importance of working for gender equality for economic and social progress.

Advances have been made globally, but there is still a long way to go. Gender parity is too far off, gender-based violence is rampant, and millions of girls are married off as child brides. Men and boys must join forces with women and girls to advance gender equality globally, from the locker rooms to the halls of power.

Overall, human rights and liberal democracy — enabling people to share thoughts and ideas freely — are essential drivers for sustainable development, along with free trade and open markets. Including everyone, irrespective of gender, sexual orientation, or race, means more hands and minds pushing for social and economic progress for all.

Mr. President,

Building back better requires greater respect for human rights, fundamental freedoms, and gender equality — the critical cornerstones for a better and more just future.

Indeed, investing in development, peace, and human rights will, at the end of the day, always be less expensive than having to address the dire consequences of poverty, war, and injustice.

Regrettably, today's conflicts, humanitarian and political crises are too often rooted in lack of respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms.

This year, we have witnessed a ruthless military coup in Myanmar, where democracy and civil rights have been done away with altogether. The situation in Afghanistan is highly troubling, with reports of attacks, serious violations of international humanitarian law, and human rights abuses, including push back against

women's rights. The Taliban and other parties must respect international law, seek an inclusive political settlement, and ensure humanitarian access and safe passage for all, or else be held accountable.

In too many places, we have seen a serious decline of respect for civil and political rights. We need to stand by those who risk their lives and liberties every day for calling out these injustices and engaging in an open, democratic debate. We have a collective duty to promote and protect the human rights and freedom of all.

The role of the Human Rights Council has never been as important as now. We need to engage in an open dialogue on how to correct the course and head towards greater respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms, everywhere and always. The run-up to the 75th anniversary of the Universal Declaration for Human Rights in 2023 should be used to reinvigorate our collective commitments to human rights.

Iceland is firmly committed to continue actively promoting and defending human rights. We have therefore decided to run for a seat on the Human Rights Council for the term 2025-2027.

Mr. President,

The complexity of modern conflicts and crises continues to grow with the marriage of emerging factors, such as climate change, cyber threats and disinformation, and the old foes of authoritarianism and tyranny.

While encouraging steps have been taken to preserve and build peace, including in Iraq and Libya, the overall trend is nothing short of disappointing.

This year's surge of violence in Palestine and Israel underlined the importance of finding ways to reinvigorate the Middle East Peace Process. Its current stagnation will only serve to deepen existing disagreements and feed senseless extremism.

Finding political solutions to the situations in Syria, Yemen, Ethiopia, and now Afghanistan is also essential, as military might alone can never deliver peace and stability.

The same holds true for Russia's persistent and unlawful violations of the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Ukraine and Georgia, which continues to undermine regional stability.

The UN's role in pursuing diplomacy and providing humanitarian and development assistance is indispensable. We are all responsible for creating and safeguarding the space for diplomacy and humanitarian work.

Still, the Security Council carries special responsibilities on behalf of the wider UN membership. The Council needs to act with greater foresight based on a broader view of security, and we welcome its recent deliberations on cyber security, climate security and the pandemic. At the same time, it is about time that we instil new life in the Security Council reform discussions, which need to become more substantive, and results focused.

Prevention needs to be our highest priority, given human cost and long-term implications of conflict, instability, and tensions. Safeguarding the key agreements that brought us out of the wasteful arms race of the Cold War, not least the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, is particularly important.

Mr. President,

There is no international platform that compares to the United Nations. No other body can bring together different nationalities, religions, and political views — literally under one roof.

It symbolises humanity's greatest aspirations and represents a beacon of hope, not least for those stricken by conflict, poverty, inequality, and discrimination.

The UN Charter and international law need to continue to be our lodestars. Without them, we will be lost and swayed by those seeking narrow national interests and zero-sum games.

But, to stay relevant, it is critical that the UN evolves with the times.

We need more transparency and openness within the UN system and among Member States.

And, perhaps most importantly, we need to bring the UN closer to the people of the world.

The UN75 Declaration provides us with a strong vision and framework for the future. I also welcome the Secretary-Generals report on Our Common Agenda on present and future challenges,

Mr. President,

Today's challenges may seem overwhelming, seen from the perspective of individual nations acting alone.

Still, united in hope and will, and by delivering on our commitments, we can meet these challenges and deliver on the promises set out in the UN Charter to safeguard peace, human rights, and development.

Our future depends on it.

Thank you.

Eritrea (see also A/76/PV.16, annex II)

Address by Mr. Osman Saleh Mohammed, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the State of Eritrea

Delivered on Monday, 27 September 2021, at the 16th meeting of the General Assembly

Your Excellency, Abdulla Shahid,

President of the General Assembly;

Your Excellency António Guterres,

Secretary general of the United Nations; Ladies and Gentlemen,

It is an honour for me to address this august Assembly of States — albeit virtually — on behalf of the President of the State of Eritrea, H.E. Mr. Isaias Afwerki.

In this regard, allow me to congratulate Your Excellency, on behalf of the Government and People of Eritrea, on your election as the President for the 76th Session of the United Nations. You have our full support as we are aware of the enormity of your responsibilities.

I also wish to express our deepest gratitude to your predecessor, His Excellency Volkan Bozkır, for his astute leadership and successful conclusion of the 75th session.

Mr. President,

These are crucial, and in many respects, unprecedented times. Our global community is facing triple challenges of enormous gravity; i) the COVID-19 pandemic whose deadly virulence continues unabated in many places; ii) spiralling climate change that threatens our very survival; and, iii) growing risks of dangerous international rivalry and commotion rooted on dynamic changes in the global balance of power.

These grave challenges have accentuated some basic truths. They have amplified the flaws and inadequacies of conventional wisdom on certain economic models. They have exposed structural deficiencies in the parameters of global and domestic governance hitherto portrayed as universal and unassailable both in terms of their universal validity and applicability.

Leaving aside the deleterious consequences of the Cold-War, misguided policies pursued in its immediate aftermath by Special Interest Groups in the US and Europe to maintain and consolidate a Uni-Polar global order did not usher in a period of international stability and prosperity that would, as it was argued, cascade down to different parts of the world to promote steady social and economic progress. As it happened, even in advanced countries, income disparity between the rich few — less than 1 per cent of the population — and the majority of other citizens has become ludicrously huge and morally reprehensible with unhealthy social ramifications.

At the international level, heavy-handed policies of containment and encirclement to forestall healthy strategic competition and mutual progress based on symmetric, equitable, and rules-based international system has, and is stoking, a climate of confrontation and instability with all the risks that this may entail in the period ahead.

In the event, it is incumbent on all of us to climb down from our high horses and ponder on these issues in a holistic manner; with requisite earnestness and sincerity.

As I intimated above, our world is still dealing with the deadly pandemic. The theme for the 76th Session — "Building resilience through hope — to recover from COVID19, rebuild sustainably, respond to the needs of the planet, respect the rights of people, and revitalize the United Nations" — is, in this sense, apt and optimistic. But as you know well, the realities facing humanity today are dire and many.

Let me take the opportunity to convey my condolences to and express my solidarity with all Member States and all the families of those who have lost loved ones due to the COVID-19 global pandemic.

Mr. President,

Whether meeting internationally agreed development goals, combating the growing threat of climate change, or responding to the range of threats to international peace and security, the enormity of today's global challenges call for a stronger United Nations that is more representative, transparent and most importantly, effective.

As we stated last year, the pursuit and ideals of enduring global peace, stability and prosperity are squarely predicated, and can only flourish, on the edifice of a robust global organization that can measure up to all these challenges. This indelible fact is more evident than ever before.

In the event, allow me to renew our call for the strengthening and revamping of the UN system whose authority and efficacy have been corroded in past decades. Unfortunately, multilateral institutions have been rendered impotent, due to the unilateral actions of a select few.

Mr. President

In the Horn of Africa, economic problems due to the COVID pandemic have been compounded by a dangerous conflict that stems from decades of misguided policies by certain major players as I will elaborate later.

To this one must also add growing tensions we have witnessed in the past months in the wider region on issues of border dispute and the Renaissance Dam. In Eritrea's view, these are not intractable problems beyond direct resolution by the parties concerned through political goodwill and good-faith negotiations to advance mutual and long-term benefits to all the principal stakeholders. In regard to the Renaissance Dam in particular, acrimonious and internationalized forums will likely hinder an enduring and comprehensive arrangement that addresses the requirements of the principal riparian States — i.e. Ethiopia, the Sudan, and Egypt — within a framework of robust and long-term cooperation and available technological options and solutions.

Mr. President,

As Your Excellency will recall, the Joint Declaration of Peace and Friendship that Eritrea and Ethiopia signed in July 2018 had ushered in a new epoch of hope and optimism. The significance of this historic achievement was vividly visible in the massive euphoria that it generated among the peoples of Eritrea and Ethiopia.

But the TPLF group could not accept and fathom the present realities. It thus embarked on multiple acts of subversion both to scuttle the Eritrea-Ethiopia peace process and to regain power in Ethiopia through forceful means.

It must be recalled here that while in power in Ethiopia, the TPLF continued to occupy, for almost two decades, sovereign Eritrean territories in flagrant violation of international law and the Arbitral Award of the Eritrea-Ethiopia Boundary Commission. Throughout this time, the TPLF continued to wage intermittent assaults against Eritrea in order to provoke a major war. And while the Eritrea-Ethiopia Peace Agreement stipulated Ethiopia's unequivocal adherence to, and implementation of the EEBC Border Verdict, the TPLF continued to obstruct good-faith enforcement of this solemn agreement.

In Ethiopia too, the TPLF resorted to various illicit subterfuges to roll back the positive process underway through popular will. And as a culmination and dangerous escalation of its subversive measures, it unleashed a massive War of Insurrection against Ethiopian's Northern Command with the express aims of neutralizing this biggest contingent, confiscating its weaponry, to thereby forcefully seize power in Ethiopia. TPLF's aims included subsequent military acts of aggression against Eritrea.

The grave danger that this reckless and illicit acts by this rogue group to Ethiopia, Eritrea and the Horn of Africa region as a whole is too evident to merit further elaboration. But what we find inexcusable is the position of certain countries, notably the US and its European allies, to defend the TPLF's illicit and dangerous acts of insurrection and mayhem and marshal all the tools in their disposal to rehabilitate it at any cost. I will not waste your time here to recount the false narratives they have floated to create moral equivalence between the principal culprit and those compelled to take deterrent and reactive action warranted by international law and established State practice.

This act in itself underlines the structural inadequacy of the global governance system that I intimated earlier in my speech. Eritrea has suffered enormously by similar previous acts. These should not recur again. The injustices meted on Eritrea by powers who feel they can trample the sovereignty of nations and peoples at their whim must indeed come to an end.

I thank you

San Marino (see also A/76/PV.16, annex III)

Address by Mr. Luca Beccari, Minister for Foreign Affairs, International Economic Cooperation and Telecommunications of the Republic of San Marino

Delivered on Monday, 27 September 2021, at the 16th meeting of the General Assembly

Mr. President,

Mr. Secretary-General,

Excellencies,

Ladies and Gentlemen,

On behalf of the Government of the Republic of San Marino, I would like to congratulate H.E. Mr. Abdulla Shahid on his election as President of the 76th Session of the UN General Assembly and to wish him a fruitful work.

The Republic of San Marino supports the priorities of your programme mentioned in your inaugural address and ensures you, Mr. President, full cooperation in all works of the General Assembly.

I would also like to express my Country's gratitude to the outgoing President, H.E. Mr. Volkan Bozkır, for the important work carried out during the 75th Session.

I also would like to extend my special thanks to the Secretary General, H.E. António Guterres, for his energy and determination in leading the United Nations in these difficult and challenging times and in the reform processes of the Organization.

San Marino welcomes the appointment of H.E. António Guterres for a second term as Secretary-General. We offer him our warmest congratulations and full support.

Mr. President,

The COVID-19 pandemic brought an unprecedented health, economic and social crisis. Health systems in many countries have been driven to the edge of collapse. The Pandemic has taken 4 million lives. Tens of millions of people are being pushed back into extreme poverty and hunger, erasing the modest progress made in recent years. More than 1.6 billion students were out of school. Many, particularly girls, may never return to school, contributing to a surge in child marriage and an increase in child labour. The livelihood of half the global workforce has been severely affected.

The coronavirus did not affect the world equally. In fact, it exposed and exacerbated existing inequalities and injustices in medical assistance around the world. Fatality rates have been highest among marginalized groups in advanced economies. In developing countries, COVID-19 hit even harder the most vulnerable.

Knowing all this, how can we stay hopeful when looking at the economic recovery before us? If this is how we dealt with the health emergency so far, how can we be sure that the economic policies that we are collectively called to implement in the upcoming years will not accentuate the existing gaps?

One thing is for sure. If we do not address these gaps, they will aggravate our current global challenges, such as migrations, access to the labour market and to education, just to name a few, and will ultimately result into amplified geopolitical instability.

Mr. President,

San Marino paid a very high price to this crisis. We reached one of the highest rates of mortality in the world. We finally recovered from this scourge thanks to a valuable reaction from our Authorities, who put in place policies based on the principle of equity. We succeeded also because of an extraordinary sense of solidarity of our People and of other Countries.

Yet, even for us, being a relatively wealthy nation in the middle of Europe, this crisis represented an exceptional struggle.

San Marino enjoys relative financial prosperity and logistical capacity. Yet, just because we are a small State, we faced alarming problems in terms of procurement of vaccines.

When finally we were able to overcome such problems by obtaining enough vaccine doses and completing a swift vaccination campaign for our population, we were actually just about to meet a different face of inequality: the inequality related to freedom of movement.

As you all know, today freedom of movement between and within countries is a prerogative that depends on what vaccine your Government was able to obtain. You might have thousands of antibodies and test negative for COVID, and yet not being allowed to enter a certain country, to enter a museum, or a sports centre, and so on.

You might understand why this is deeply troubling for a Country like mine, which is just 60 square kilometres.

This is why San Marino makes an urgent appeal to our family of Nations.

We must learn lessons from this crisis in order to fill the existing economic and social gaps and be better prepared for similar existential threats in the future.

We must secure even access around the world to COVID-19 vaccines, tests, treatments and support, in order to prevent virus' mutations and new clusters of infections.

The COVID-19 crisis underscored the indispensable role of international cooperation through the United Nations to overcome a shared global challenge.

In these critical times, we must strengthen, more than ever, the political will and leadership to support multilateralism and reinforce the rules-based international order.

In this increasingly globalized and interconnected world, it is imperative to build a flexible system that is able to adapt on the different peculiarities of our Countries and to react quickly to multiple challenges at the same time, to be responsive to the needs of people, everywhere, ensuring that geopolitical interests do not prevail and that no one is left behind.

Mr. President,

The peace and security international context became increasingly fragmented.

The nature of conflicts is evolving due to the growing interconnections between scarce natural resources, climate change, socioeconomic vulnerabilities, disinformation and cyber-attacks.

Despite our efforts, in many areas of the world vulnerable populations are still facing the threat of mass atrocities.

The Government of the Republic of San Marino is deeply concerned for the ongoing crisis in Afghanistan, Myanmar, Syria, Yemen, Palestine and elsewhere.

The situation in Afghanistan is of particular concern.

San Marino supports any effort aiming at providing humanitarian assistance to

Afghanistan and calls on all parties to allow full, safe, and unhindered access for the United Nations, its specialized agencies and implementing partners, and all humanitarian actors engaged in humanitarian relief activity.

We also reiterate the importance of protecting human rights including those of women, children and minorities.

In this respect, we cannot but support the UN Security Council Resolution 2593 (2021) and thank the Secretary-General for having convened the High-Level Ministerial Meeting on the humanitarian situation in Afghanistan on September 13 and for his continuous efforts on this matter.

We also support the commitment of the Secretary-General to strengthen the UN system's ability to tackle different conflicts from a prevention-oriented perspective, as well as seeking to invest more in preventing crises.

The Government of the Republic of San Marino is worried about a deteriorating international security environment and for the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction.

In its long history, my Country has always stood for a world free of weapons of mass destruction. We are particularly concerned about the rising nuclear risks. The catastrophic humanitarian consequences of nuclear weapons constitute an existential threat to humanity and for this reason, the Republic of San Marino is a strong supporter of the new Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons.

Mr. President,

There is no doubt that the COVID-19 pandemic has endangered the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development to its very core. We don't have to let this crisis hinder our ambitions and hopes, because the principles underpinning the Sustainable Development Goals are essential to build back better in the post COVID-19 recovery.

Last year we entered in the Decade of Action to deliver the SDGs by 2030.

Now, it is critical to accelerate responses to the world's serious challenges.

With the presentation of its first Voluntary National Review on July 13, San Marino renewed its commitment to a better, fairer and more sustainable world, not only for the benefit of its citizens today but also for future generations, in our Country and everywhere else.

Mr. President,

The collective fight against climate change represents the gravest emergency of our time. This must be the top priority of our efforts.

As the impacts of climate change are becoming more visible, biodiversity loss will also become pervasive and ultimately devastating. If current trends continue, the Earth could lose the natural wealth of its ecosystems, which would in turn jeopardize global food security, water supplies, and livelihoods.

We are witnessing the grave impact of climate change on the Small Island Developing States in the Pacific, but also in other parts of the planet.

People of the world, in particular young people, demand urgent action in order to rebuild the fundamental aspects and relationship with the environment.

We will be able to reach this goal only through the full implementation of the Paris Agreement, but also by promoting important investments in adaptation and resilience.

Emerging from COVID-19 pandemic could represents an opportunity to work better on the green transition in sectors of energy, transport, tourism, aviation, agriculture, industry and infrastructure.

Mr. President,

The situation for people with disabilities has further worsened: the pandemic has deepened the difficulties in accessing education, healthcare and in participating in the life of their communities.

The international community has the duty to address this situation.

San Marino attaches great importance to the promotion and protection of rights for people with disabilities and we are honoured that the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights has recognized as a promising practice the guidance on triage produced by the Bioethics Committee of San Marino, which prohibited discrimination on the basis of disability.

Realizing the rights of persons with disabilities is central for the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and for our promise to leave no one behind.

We need to build accessible, inclusive and non-discriminatory societies, where people with disabilities can fully participate in the political, social and economic aspects of the community, where they are involved in the decision-making process and where their value is fully recognized.

Mr. President,

The United Nations must adapt quickly not only to the new global challenges, but also to the new opportunities offered by an increasingly interconnected world, in order to be more effective in carrying out its mandate.

Therefore, reforms are crucial to future world stability and maintenance of international peace and security, and must remain at the centre of our actions.

The Republic of San Marino is following with interest the revitalization process of the UN General Assembly, which must continue to be a reference point, a forum for the exchange of ideas and for conducting discussions, in which solutions based on a strong consensus may be achieved.

Similarly, the Security Council reform should be an objective of all member States. As we have stated on previous occasions, our Country believes that intergovernmental negotiations favour the search for an agreement based on a broad and strong political consensus, able to reflect the interests of all negotiating groups.

San Marino calls for a reform that makes the Council more democratic, transparent, efficient and accountable. This goal can be achieved only through a continuous dialogue among the States and the awareness that overcoming the respective initial positions is essential to negotiate the broadest agreement possible.

Mr. President,

To address the many and complex challenges of today, Member States must assume their responsibilities and the United Nations must be more effective and flexible in order to be able to fulfil its mandate, which is to protect the citizens of the world.

San Marino is a State with a strong identity thanks to its century-old history of peace and freedom. Our State is small, but proud to bring its contribution to the United Nations Community.

Thank you for your attention.

Oman (see also A/76/PV.16, annex IV)

Address by Mr. Sayyid Badr bin Hamad bin Hamood Albusaidi, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Sultanate of Oman

Delivered on Monday, 27 September 2021, at the 16th meeting of the General Assembly

[Original: Arabic and English]

Excellency, President Abdulla Shahid,

At the outset, it gives us pleasure to extend my congratulations to you and your friendly country, the Republic of Maldives on your election, as President of the Seventy-sixth Session of the United Nations General Assembly. We are confident that you are capable of conducting the work of this session with much wisdom and skill.

We also like to express our thanks and appreciation to your predecessor, His Excellency Volkan Bozkır of the friendly Republic of Turkey, for his efforts while presiding over the previous session.

We would also like to place on record our appreciation for the efforts of His Excellency Secretary-General António Guterres, wishing him every success in his second term of office, and assuring the Sultanate of Oman's continued cooperation with him, and other Member States to achieve the noble aims of the United Nations, the foremost of which is the maintenance of international peace and security.

Mr. President,

Crises and challenges represent opportunities for countries in testing their readiness and enhancing capabilities. Despite the great challenges and changes inflicted by the novel coronavirus pandemic "COVID-19" on our daily lives; but thank goodness that did not discourage us from confronting those challenges, addressing their repercussions, and working toward recovery.

In the Sultanate of Oman, the availability of vaccines had a great impact in strengthening our national efforts to address this pandemic, and consolidating hope for its elimination and gradual return to normal life. My country has been able, through preventive measures and a national vaccination campaign for all targeted ages, to limit the spread of the epidemic, reduce the number of infections and deaths, and the rate of hospitalization, which has enabled the return of economic, social and commercial activities to normalcy, and opening of all travel and movement exits, while putting in place the necessary preventive measures.

As we continue our efforts to confront this pandemic, we call on the international community to enhance cooperation and solidarity, and we appeal to vaccine-producing and donor countries to do their utmost to ensure a fair distribution for all countries and individuals, particularly in less developed regions that suffer from limited facilities and medical capabilities, which would bring about international cooperation and societal solidarity, and ensure a decent life for human beings across the globe.

Bearing that in mind, we seize this opportunity to salute those in charge of health systems, especially in the first line of defence, in all countries of the world and international organizations for the enormous efforts and sacrifice that they are making for the sake of all mankind.

Mr. President,

Under the wise leadership of His Majesty Sultan Haitham bin Tariq, the Sultanate of Oman continues to adhere to the established and main principles of its foreign policy, which are embodied in the policy of good-neighbourliness, non-interference in the internal affairs of others, respect for international laws and norms, enhance cooperation among States and opportunities for dialogue. We firmly believe that resolving differences in the spirit of reconciliation and tolerance is a civilized conduct that leads to better and more lasting results, than can be achieved through conflict. Simply put, dialogue is better than war.

We, in the Sultanate of Oman, are part of this interconnected world; we share interests and destiny with its people. We rejoice for its contentment and grieve for its impairment. Therefore, we strive with our full energy and capabilities to contribute in assisting peace issues at all regional and international levels. We are committed to our stances with honesty, objectivity, steadfastness on our values and principles, as well as a balanced and constructive approach in dealing with all issues.

From this standpoint, my country welcomed and supported the positive developments that resulted from the Al-Ula summit that was held in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, and the success of the reconciliation efforts led by the brotherly State of Kuwait.

We also affirm our support for the just Palestinian Cause and the demands of the Palestinian people for independence and the establishment of their State, with East Jerusalem as its capital, in accordance with international law, Security Council resolutions and the Arab Peace Initiative.

With respect to the Yemeni crisis, my country is continuing its tireless endeavours, and working with the brotherly Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, both the United Nations' and American's envoys for Yemen, and the concerned Yemeni parties with the aim of ending the war through a comprehensive and permanent ceasefire on all sides, and fully resuming humanitarian efforts, in order to provide for the needs of the brothers in Yemen. In particular, medication, health care, food, fuel and housing. We join our voice with everyone who believes in the inevitability of reaching a comprehensive political settlement to the existing crisis, in a way that restores security, stability, and normalcy to brotherly Yemen, while maintaining the security and interests of countries of the Region.

We would also like to express our hope that the Vienna talks on the Iranian nuclear program will lead to the desired consensus among all parties, because we firmly believe that this will be in the interest of the Region and the world.

Like the rest of the world, we have followed the recent developments in Afghanistan; we would, therefore, like to express our hope that all Afghan parties will work for reconciliation and give priority to the higher interests of the Afghan people and their aspirations for security, stability, economic and social development, and building positive relations with regional neighbours and the international community.

Mr. President,

My country condemns terrorism in all its forms and manifestations, and in the meantime, supports efforts and strategies to eradicate this haunting menace that contradicts religious and human values and morals, and threatens security and stability in the entire world.

In addition, the Sultanate of Oman calls for ending threats to international maritime trade and for full compliance with treaties, agreements and international law to ensure freedom of maritime navigation in a manner that secures the flow of trade among countries and enhances economic growth opportunities. We call upon all Member States to fulfil their commitments undertaken through treaties and agreements related to disarmament, in particular, those agreements and treaties relating to nuclear weapons and other weapons of mass destruction, in order to ensure global stability.

Mr. President,

My country has sought to translate its international commitment in achieving the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals 2030 (SDGs), by integrating its three economic and social axes, and the 17 SDGs into the Sultanate's strategies and developmental plans. We also consider those SDGs, as key components of the Oman's Vision 2040 and its implementation plans.

We are fully aware that the road to sustainable development is still long and bumpy, and that achieving the commitments we made depends on our ability to face challenges, which requires joint international and regional cooperation. In this context, we recognize that a renewed commitment to social justice represents the real basis for action at the national and international policy levels. Therefore, we welcome and support the investment and economic diversification programs, which are among the priorities of development plans in the Sultanate of Oman; thereby, contributing to the maximization and dissemination of benefits and opportunities for our partners and society.

Like other countries of the world, my country pays great attention to the risks of climate change that affect the ecological and agricultural systems, and the economic infrastructure. Hence, to confront climate change and limit its increasing effects, the Sultanate of Oman has implemented its Draft National Strategy for adapting to climate change and mitigating its effects. This strategy includes reports on the expected impacts of the most important sectors of development and the appropriate adaptation measures for them.

My country recently submitted its second Nationally Determined Contributions (NDC) report to mitigate Greenhouse Gas (GHG) Emissions, as part of its commitments to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change.

The world is witnessing new transformations as a result of scientific and technological progress, which calls on us, once more, to emphasize the importance of strengthening the global- partnership in this field, so as to maximize the use of advanced technologies and keep pace with them, as part of the sustainable development goals, and face contemporary challenges, the most important of which are those that threaten the climate.

Mr. President,

There is no doubt that women have a great role alongside men in building a social fabric that ensures the sound education of young people, on whom, the hopes of nations are held. As you may know that the youth are the hope of the present and the pillar of the future, upon which countries depend to achieve development. Therefore, it was necessary for governments to place among their priorities the attention attached to youth and to provide everything that would advance their capabilities. I affirm my country's commitment to empowering women and youth

to acquire the capabilities and knowledge they need to actively participate in the process of construction, development, creativity and prosperity.

In conclusion, Mr. President,

We have urgent issues, facing the International Community that must be addressed through international cooperation, in order to reach the aspirations of humanity, in terms of stability, harmony and prosperity. Hence, we believe that consolidating the real concept of partnership and common destiny among all peoples and societies is the best way to realize those hopes and maximize the prestigious position that the United Nations yearns for achieving and sustaining.

Thank you, for your kind attention, and peace be upon you!

Brunei Darussalam (see also A/76/PV.16, annex V)

Address by Dato Seri Paduka Awang Haji Erywan bin Pehin Datu Pekerma Jaya Haji Mohd Yusof, Minister for Foreign Affairs II of Brunei Darussalam

Delivered on Monday, 27 September 2021, at the 16th meeting of the General Assembly

Bismillahirrahmanirrahim

Mr. President,

Mr. Secretary-General,

Excellencies,

Ladies and Gentlemen,

Assalamualaikum warahmatullahi wabarakatuh and Peace Be Upon You All

Let me at the outset, convey the warm greetings of His Majesty the Sultan and Yang Di-Pertuan of Brunei Darussalam to this august assembly.

I would also like to congratulate His Excellency Abdulla Shahid on assuming the Presidency of the Seventy-Sixth Session of the General Assembly, and wish him much success in his new role.

I wish to also congratulate Secretary-General António Guterres on his re-appointment. This serves as a testament of Member States' confidence towards his able leadership, and I welcome his continued dedication and commitment towards serving the international community.

Mr. President,

For more than 18 months, Brunei Darussalam, and the rest of the world, continues to face the challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic. After a year of being free of local transmissions, Brunei Darussalam now faced another wave of the pandemic.

In our efforts to control the spread of the virus and its variants, the Government of His Majesty has swiftly implemented several measures, similar to other countries, including restricted movements and international travel as well as ramping up vaccination efforts.

Although our experience is one of many that demonstrates the need to remain vigilant, it is still vaccinations that is key to controlling the spread and ensure the safety of our people.

However, the current global system of vaccine distribution remains to be of much concern. Although over 3.5 billion doses of vaccines have been distributed globally, 75 per cent of these vaccines only go to 10 countries. On top of that, low-income countries are only able to vaccinate less than 2 per cent of their population.

It is therefore urgent for Members States to work together with pharmaceutical companies to ensure that COVAX are able to fulfil its commitments to supply and deliver equitable, accessible and affordable vaccines for all.

The message of the Secretary-General rings true — no one is safe until everyone is safe.

As we recover from the pandemic, another long-term challenge that is emerging due to repeated lockdowns and quarantines, is the issue of mental health.

If remain unaddressed, our next generation of workforce and the generation after that will be greatly affected, ultimately resulting in the slowdown of the global economy and developmental progress.

In this regard, we welcome the inclusion of an indicator on preparedness for providing mental health and psychosocial support during emergencies in the Comprehensive Mental Health Action Plan by the World Health Assembly.

In our region, Brunei Darussalam is working closely with Australia and Malaysia in adopting the East Asia Leaders Statement on Mental Health Cooperation in October at the 16th East Asia Summit.

This will help strengthen regional efforts towards addressing mental health, and encourage other member states to take concrete collective action in promoting better mental health in the region.

At the crux of it all, the people's health and well-being are fundamental to build back better and stronger towards a resilient global community.

Mr. President,

In addressing the adverse impacts of the pandemic, it has not only compromised ongoing national development plans but also the resources of many countries, notably the small developing states, and recently there have been reports that the effects of the pandemic will inevitably delay progress towards achieving the 2030 Agenda.

In this regard, we must ensure that our recovery efforts prioritise the recovery of our economies by ramping up trade and investments so that livelihoods and employment can recover quickly.

This means we must continue to uphold free and open trade and investments, encourage greater technological collaboration and transfer, as well as strengthen global developmental cooperation to ensure no country is left behind.

In pursuing our recovery plans from the pandemic, it is also timely for us to incorporate green initiatives.

This is because the threat of climate change continues to exist during the pandemic, and the recent forecast of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) report is not positive at all.

We already made commitments under the Paris Agreement, and all that remains is for us to uphold and implement them.

In this important 'climate year', we welcome the UK's Presidency and hosting of the COP26, and their calls for the world to come together, deliver, and raise climate ambitions where possible. We look forward to a meaningful outcome at the COP26 in Glasgow, that would set the tone and direction for global efforts in the future.

In our region, we are launching the ASEAN Framework for Circular Economy to close the loop on finite resource wastage while enhancing economic growth and reducing pressure on the environment.

Mr. President,

ASEAN, under the Chairmanship of Brunei Darussalam this year, with the theme — We Care, We Prepare, We Prosper — intends to make good on the promise of building resilience through hope.

The alignment with the General Assembly's theme shows the importance of ensuring that there is hope for our people and planet in the future.

Our ASEAN deliverables also demonstrate our commitment to maintaining regional peace and security.

This is why this year, when the situation in one of our fellow ASEAN family member could affect the stability of the region, ASEAN Leaders quickly met and agreed on the Five-Point Consensus to ensure a peaceful return to democracy in that member state in accordance to the will and interests of its people.

The Five-Point Consensus, among others, also calls for an immediate cessation of violence as well as for the commencement of dialogue among all parties concerned and to allow for the provision of humanitarian assistance.

To this end, on behalf of ASEAN, I would like to express our deepest gratitude to our external partners, including the United Nations, for their assistance and also for the generous contributions accorded at the Humanitarian Pledging Conference last month.

We welcome the continued support of the international community in ASEAN's efforts.

Mr. President,

The question of Palestine remains very much in our thoughts for over seven decades. Up until now, there has not been any concrete resolution.

We continue to see forced eviction, destruction of homes and expansion of illegal settlements by the Occupying Power. This has not only deprived the Palestinians of their basic human rights but also have denied them of any chance for their right to self-determination.

The UN Security Council has a special responsibility to call for cessation of all violence, and fulfil its obligations of upholding international peace and work towards finding a comprehensive and lasting peace on the basis of the two-state solution.

We also call on the international community to remain resolute in their commitment to safeguarding the two-state solution towards achieving an independent state of Palestine based on the pre1967 borders, with East Jerusalem as its capital.

Mr. President,

Brunei Darussalam stands here today to reiterate our support and commitment to preserving international peace and security, promote prosperity and sustainable development, underpinned by the adherence to international obligations and rule of law, as enshrined in the UN Charter.

Let us move forward in this new normal, with the renewed spirit of upholding multilateralism and continued hope to achieve international peace, prosperity and security for all of our people.

Thank you.

France (see also A/76/PV.16, annex VI)

Address by Mr. Jean-Yves Le Drian, Minister for Europe and Foreign Affairs of France

Delivered on Monday, 27 September 2021, at the 16th meeting of the General Assembly

[Original: English and French]

President of the General Assembly,

Secretary-General,

Heads of State and Government,

Heads of Delegation,

By reminding us of the extent to which our destinies are linked — for better and for worse — the pandemic crisis has reminded us of the value of what has united us at this organization for over 75 years. The will to cooperate, the primacy of law over force, unconditional respect for the human person: the principles of our Charter have not lost any of their meaning. In fact, quite the opposite.

Today's crises and challenges have made them even more essential.

Our security, our health and our planet are now common goods, which together we must strive to preserve. This imperative is not abstract, it is not an ideal.

It is, in very concrete terms, the perspective of each of our choices.

And just as definitively, it is our punishment each time we are divided, each time we give up, each time we are powerless.

Because in a world of exchanges and interdependencies, a world with environmental emergencies, a world facing worrying attitudes of brutalization and the constant temptation of unilateralism, everything that we do together — and conversely, everything that we fail to do — involves us all. We must be aware of this and learn lessons from it. Together.

Although the foundations of the multilateral system have remained solid in the face of attacks in recent years, too many uncontrolled risks are building up. On behalf of France, my first message to you today is thus one of responsibility.

Our first shared responsibility is to maintain international peace and security.

And it is in danger when power games are heightened, when bloc mentalities reappear, when our regulatory frameworks collapse, when attempts at fait accompli policies increase.

That is why France is calling for a P5 Summit to set out a joint action programme.

To enable the Security Council to fully exercise its mandate.

And to start dialogue on the key issues of arms control and our collective security.

And that is why we are taking action and will continue to do so for peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific with our willing partners in the region and other Europeans alongside us. As an Indo-Pacific nation, France has major interests in the region, as does Europe which has just set out a strategy in this area.

International peace and security is thus at risk each time a crisis breaks out or reaches a new level. In Afghanistan, our duty is to provide the people with necessary humanitarian assistance and it is in our common interest to have clear political and security requirements with regard to the regime in Kabul: all links with terrorist organizations must be severed.

Twenty years after the events of September 11, we know what a rebuilt haven for terrorists would mean for us.

In the Levant and the Sahel, we must, for the same reason, continue to fight the terrorist threat, work to restore dialogue where it has broken down and give the people new prospects for the future by working towards stability and development.

Recently, the President of the French Republic, Emmanuel Macron, travelled to Baghdad to support the Iraqis' determined efforts to come together and restore their sovereignty.

In the Sahel, we are adapting our military structure to retain our long-term action capabilities, to meet the expectations of our regional partners and to remain fully available to our international partners, those from the Coalition for the Sahel and those serving within MINUSMA. These efforts, which are producing real results, as can be seen by the recent killing of Abu Walid Al-Sahrawi, are not sustainable without political stability and respect for the democratic process. I particularly have in mind the timetable for elections in Mali, which must be strictly observed.

In Libya, there is now a credible path to restore unity and sovereignty in the country, provided that all parties fulfil their obligations, the foreign mercenaries withdraw, the ceasefire remains in place and elections are held as planned on 24 December.

France hopes that the Security Council, Libya's neighbours and those which have influence over the country can collaborate to achieve our shared objective of completing the ongoing transition. This is the aim of the international conference to support the political process and restore sovereignty in Libya, which we will host in Paris on 12 November.

Whether in the divided Middle East, along the contact line in Ukraine, in Nagorno-Karabakh or the South Caucasus, where the risk of conflict still cannot be ruled out, we must prevent tensions, uphold international law and collectively support the implementation of concrete political solutions. With regard to the Iranian nuclear programme, we must be absolutely unequivocal. Iran cannot be allowed to think time is on its side, because the more dangerous its nuclear programme becomes, the greater the risk of a major crisis.

The positions taken by the United States yesterday cannot justify Iran's continued violation of its JCPOA commitments.

France will take all necessary action to encourage dialogue. But the only possible path remains an agreement to establish that Iran is once again fulfilling its obligations. It is therefore essential that negotiations resume very quickly.

Violations of international humanitarian law also constitute a serious threat to international peace and security.

Particularly when humanitarian and medical personnel are targeted, even as they are providing emergency relief to populations. We must therefore equip

ourselves with the means to better prevent these crimes and punish those who are guilty of committing them — in Syria, Yemen, Niger, the Central African Republic, Ethiopia and everywhere else.

Our responsibility — ladies and gentlemen — is also to build pragmatic and inclusive responses to the major global challenges that determine our shared future.

Starting with the COVID-19 challenge which is not yet behind us.

We need to be very clear: the health of some depends on the health of all. We must therefore pursue efforts that, through the ACT-A initiative, have already provided 255 million vaccine doses to 141 countries. We cannot allow the vaccine divide between the North and the South to widen any further.

Because the very meaning and credibility of multilateralism is at stake.

And because we know that if immunity is not global, there will be no immunity.

There is an urgent need to accelerate deliveries to ensure that each vaccine delivered is administered properly and to strengthen our production capacities on all continents.

France will continue to work in close cooperation with its partners, especially those in Africa.

Our commitment to provide 60 million doses will be achieved by the end of the year.

And we are proud to contribute to the financing of a project to transfer technology to South Africa, which should help Africa develop autonomous production capacities of mRNA vaccines.

International solidarity must also prevail when it comes to the other challenge of the pandemic crisis: the challenge of economic recovery.

A response to the emergency was provided with the debt deferment initiative that we took at the G20 and the establishment of a common framework that can now be used for its implementation.

But we must go further by building a new pact with Africa that President Macron called for at the Summit on the Financing of African Economies in May 2021.

The G20 must commit to ensuring that the allocation of special drawing rights we decided upon in the IMF is swiftly supplemented by the reallocation of a portion of them to countries which need them most.

France is ready to transfer 20 per cent of its SDR allocation to African economies to strengthen the resilience of societies and support the transition to a sustainable development model and meet our objectives for the climate and the environment.

The environmental emergency must be at the heart of each of our future choices.

Without succumbing to fatalism, because the IPCC experts have told us that if we swiftly lower our emissions, we can still limit warming to 2°C or even 1.5°C. We must act urgently, but it is not too late! However when we act it must be with no half measures, because — as the Secretary-General has firmly stated — we are now on a catastrophic pathway due to insufficient commitments that are leading us to global heating of 2.7°C for which we will all, without exception, pay a heavy price.

COP26 which will begin on 1 November will therefore be a moment of truth.

Each of us must shoulder our responsibility and provide a contribution that is commensurate with what is at stake. Namely human lives, international stability, and the future of the generations to come. We must rally around the objective of climate neutrality by 2050 before it is too late. Here again, France will show its solidarity by providing €6 billion a year and devoting more than a third of its financing to climate adaptation.

This fight for the climate must go hand in hand with the fight for biodiversity. In Marseille at the IUCN World Conservation Congress, held in early September, we made strong commitments, that we must now implement, particularly the symbolic project of the Great Green Wall for the Sahara and Sahel.

We must also put climate finance to work for biodiversity, as the connections between the two topics are now well recognized.

During this time of global economy recovery, we must lastly ensure that our trade practices are fully compatible with our international solidarity efforts and our climate and environmental objectives. By providing new levers in accordance with WTO law, such as the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism that we wish to establish in Europe to fight carbon leakage, in the same way that we wish to fight imported deforestation and violations of social rights across our value chains. And by working, at the same time, on a tangible "greening" of the multilateral trade framework at the WTO ministerial meeting this year, starting with an ambitious agreement for regulating fisheries subsidies. The future of our oceans depend on it.

We also have a responsibility with regard to the very principles of multilateralism, of which we are the guardians.

The responsibility, first of all, to preserve our ability to act in the name of these principles and promote a truly multilateral order.

In this regard, Secretary-General, I would like to commend your action and your efforts to inject new impetus into the United Nations system. We will work by your side throughout your second term.

While supporting our collective institutions, including in their reform efforts, we must also continue to develop project multilateralism.

That of the Alliance for Multilateralism, which we launched two years ago with my German colleague and which was able to play its full role from the start of the pandemic.

And the International Alliance for the Protection of Heritage in Conflict Areas, which is doing an outstanding job in Iraq, Syria, Mali and Afghanistan, in cooperation with UNESCO.

We have the responsibility to defend these principles where they are wavering.

In Afghanistan, where the achievements of the last 20 years cannot be erased. Particularly when it comes to the access to education and the rights of women and girls.

And everywhere where the universal scope of human rights is being challenged.

Because universal human rights are the first political and legal translation of the unity of humankind, without which this organization, our organization, would

have no foundation. This is a commitment — I would like to recall — that the United Nations Member States freely consented to sign and respect. These principles that unite us, we have the responsibility to keep them alive today, by upholding them up to and including the digital realm.

We have seen increasingly irresponsible behaviours flourish, without managing, unfortunately, to provide an international normative response to regulate them and to ensure that the rights and freedoms of all are respected.

The introduction of a minimum universal 15 per cent tax for multinational companies will help achieve this.

We therefore call on all States to support this vital measure.

France and its European partners even intend to adopt actual legislation on digital markets. We encourage our international partners to follow us down this path, and we invite them to work with us to establish a new digital public order in the wake of the Paris Call and the Christchurch Call to Action, which, since 2019, has enabled us to take decisive action to remove terrorist content from the Internet.

Collective responsibility in international peacekeeping and security; shared responsibility in tackling today's major challenges; responsibility of each of us with regard to what unites us: for France this is what the historic turning point we are experiencing calls for. We must all rise to the challenge. While our country is preparing to take over the Presidency of the Council of the European Union in the first half of 2022, you can — ladies and gentlemen — count on our de-termination to fully assume our share of this three-pronged responsibility.

Engaging us in all the security, solidarity and equality combats.

To rebuild, with you, our shared world.

Thank you.